Jhourney

— CHAPTER ONE · FREE

Chapter one

The core technique and your first experiments, from the Jhourney retreat curriculum

Adapted from Jhourney Retreat Instructions v6.0.3 (2026), sections 1–3, 5 and 9 · 25 min

WHY WE'RE SHARING THIS

This is the opening of the instruction booklet every Jhourney retreat participant works from: the core ideas, the basic technique, and the first experiments. We're giving it away because the technique is simple enough to start tonight, and because it works best when you run it yourself rather than read about it. Treat it like a map on a hike: skim it, sit, then come back with questions.

Core ideas

The real value of jhana practice is not the jhanas themselves; it's making it easier to be the person you aspire to be

Most people hear about the jhanas as altered states—profound bliss or peace. That's true, but incomplete.

The benefits begin even before reaching jhana. Pre-jhana practice builds emotional openness and curiosity. You learn to welcome emotions you've avoided, relate to goals playfully rather than through striving, replace your inner critic with self-compassion, and develop agency through experimentation.

> I haven't gotten into jhana yet, but this has already been life-changing.
>
> Retreat participant

> Rather than get hooked on bliss states, access to emotional safety led me to naturally allow a wider range of emotions than ever before.
>
> Retreat participant

While the jhanas create positive emotion, they transform the experience of every emotion. Dropping resistance to an emotion changes your experience entirely. You can imagine grief that feels light and openhearted—like crying in a loved one's arms about a loss, perfectly relaxed, treasuring the love with the grief. One saying goes, "It hurts more, but bothers me less."

The striving trap is your first meditation object

One of the most valuable things about jhana practice is that it presents a rare paradox: **you can't crave a jhana and get into jhana.**

For many of us, goals are contracts to self-criticize until we succeed. You can think of jhanas as indicators that we've learned to spot and change this habit. This is a powerful life skill.

Imagine a spectrum of relating to a goal from:

- **Desperation** – "I need the jhana or I'm a failure or going to be doomed to sadness forever"
- **Obligation** – "I should get to jhana. It will fulfill my word or reputation."
- **Want** – "I would really like this."
- **Play** – "This is going to be a blast, like playing my favorite sport or dancing to my favorite song when nobody is looking. I can't believe life installed trapdoors in my own nervous system, and I've got time to go on a scavenger hunt."

The same goal in each of these cases, with a different way of relating to them, will lead to wildly different experiences. The last one is much more likely to get into jhana than the first three. The first two may be impossible.

Which raises the question: *How might we shift our perspective in our inner world so that play is possible?* That's a terrific line of inquiry. If you spend all your practice time pondering that question, you're likely to have a great time, and the takeaways will be invaluable, whether or not you experience jhana.

Distinguishing between object and relation

Everything in experience has two parts: the object and how we relate to it. Two people can relate to the same rollercoaster ride completely differently—one terrified, one delighted.

Jhana meditation is fundamentally about changing how we relate to sensations. When you allow sensations—relate with acceptance rather than resistance—they transform in surprising ways. When you allow rain on your head, it bugs you less. When you allow an emotion, pleasure naturally arises.

Allowing unlocks jhana. Actively trying to make a sensation bigger is resisting it – one of the biggest beginner mistakes. The opposite is allowing – sinking in like slipping into a warm bath.

We are here to become skilled at a particular kind of relaxation.

Three core phrases

We often boil down all of jhana practice to one of three phrases, each pointing at the same idea:

- **"Awareness and love all the way down."** At every level, jhana practice is loving awareness toward experience.
- **"Recursive self-acceptance."** Trouble accepting an emotion? Accept the trouble. Resist acceptance? Accept that. Notice striving → accept striving → accept resistance to accepting striving → accept frustration with this process. You can laugh at the absurdity.
- **"Spot and release mental tension."** Each layer of tension is conflict between parts of your system and an opportunity for greater release.

If you're stuck, you either have an awareness problem (can't spot what's tense) or a love problem (can't embrace what you've spotted).

Safety & regulation

> HEADS UP
>
> Meditation isn’t about pushing through—it’s about learning to stay connected. Every nervous system has an optimal range where learning, curiosity, and joy are easiest. This section helps you recognize when you’re in that range and how to return to it when you’re not.

The Window of Tolerance

Your window of tolerance is the range in which you feel both safe and alive—alert enough to engage, relaxed enough to learn. When you drift outside it, experience becomes either too much (hyperarousal) or too little (dissociation / hypoarousal).

In some traditions, the solution to any challenge in meditation is believed to be more meditation, and taking breaks is believed to be less important than practice. Not so at Jhourney. Like an elite athlete treating rest and recovery with the same respect they treat their practice, we want to ensure our nervous systems are operating at their best, accelerate learning, and eliminate unnecessary risk of injury. “Powering through” is NOT good practice; it’s careless.

Think of your nervous system like a car dashboard:

- **Green light = Learning Zone:** calm, curious, playful, emotionally available.
- **Yellow light = Warning:** irritation, fatigue, numbness, over-focus, or shakiness.
- **Red light = Outside the Window:** panic, derealization, or shutdown.

When any light appears, don't ignore it—adjust. You're learning to drive the mind safely.

Hyperarousal (too much energy). Typical signs: racing thoughts · tight chest · shaking · panic · over-intense focus · flashbacks · emotional volatility. Self-check: *"Am I feeling too much right now?"* Corrective action, "tap the brakes":

- Shorter meditations
- Use a wider, looser aperture of attention, especially outside the body
- Open your eyes / move them around
- Use titration with intense emotions (e.g., 90% focus on a safe resource, 10% on the difficult sensation)

Dissociation / hypoarousal (too little energy). Typical signs: feeling numb · spaced-out · flat · foggy · frozen · emotionally blunted · time distortions · mind feels "blank". Self-check: *"Do I feel disconnected or far away right now?"* Corrective action, "apply gas":

- Increase social connection
- Increase movement
- Shift focus, especially outside the body, to a safe or neutral experience
- Increase conceptual thought (concepts, language)

Perhaps the most commonly confused signal around the WoT in meditation is distinguishing between dissociation and calmness. Both can feel deceptively peaceful or "deep," but dissociation reduces connection whereas calm (AKA "peaceful abiding") increases it.

SAFETY & CHOICE GUIDELINES

You're always in charge of your own experience. You can pause, move, or stop any practice at any time, and modify posture (sit, lie down, stand, or walk) whenever your body asks. **Always stay within your window of tolerance.** If any instruction seems like it's going to take you outside of your WoT, ignore it. Interpret any instruction as assuming you're comfortably within your WoT. Regulation is not losing progress—it is the practice. If you feel persistently anxious, disconnected, or unsure what's happening, stop practicing and talk to someone you trust or a qualified professional.

Intense or unusual experiences are common in this practice — vivid energy, tingling, shaking, crying, lightness, or shifts in how you sense your body or self. These aren't signs of success or failure, pathology or enlightenment; they're simply ways the nervous system adapts and releases tension. Treat them as data points: pause, ground, and note whether you feel more connected or less connected. The goal is always connection.

Meditation technique at-a-glance

Dancing is a good analogy for meditation. In both, you start with very simple steps that, with time, reveal layers of depth and nuance, all of which can become second nature when you slip into flow states.

This section outlines the core meditation technique. We list the essentials first, followed by details designed to help you avoid mistakes and focus on the right things.

But the details aren't always that important to focus on. Performance comes from flow towards simple goals: great tennis players know that the thing that really matters is returning the volley, the technique is all in service of that one simple thing. If you find yourself losing the forest for the trees, getting caught up in thinking about mechanics, you can always come back to this section and the Core ideas.

Objective

- Find an openhearted feeling.
- Gently maintain your attention on this openhearted feeling, relating to it gently and openly, so that it grows naturally.

Technique at-a-glance

The basic technique has a few simple steps:

1

RELAX

Relax as deeply as you can.

2

FIND THE FEELING

Find a mild, openhearted feeling by using a smile, a happy memory, or a phrase like “May you be happy.”

3

REST AND REFRESH

Gently rest your attention on the feeling, and periodically refresh the feeling every 5-30 seconds, using the same technique you used to start it in the first place.

4

DEEPEN

Gradually relate to the feeling with more curiosity, relaxation, and enjoyment. As a sit progresses, your capacity to do this will often deepen.

5

WELCOME DISTRACTIONS

Welcome distractions when they happen. Relax any associated mental tension, physically relax, and gently return to the openhearted feeling.

You know you’re doing this effectively when you find your meditations leave you:

- More relaxed
- In a better mood (even if the sits contain difficult emotions)
- Softer, more open, more curious, and more empathic

It only takes a few hours for the basic technique to become second nature. The bulk of practice is following your intuition to open up in three ways:

- **Relaxation**—How might I relax into this even more?
- **Enjoyment**—How might I enjoy this even more?
- **Curiosity**—How might I get more curious about this, let it fill me with more awe or wonder, or even overwhelm me?

With time, you'll notice this leads you to more effortlessness:

- **"Collectedness"** - clarity, sensitivity, continuous, and stable attention—it may begin to feel as if, for moments in time, nothing else exists but the object of attention
- **"Conductivity"** - easy receptivity to the world around you, easy acceptance of any thoughts or emotions that come up

We find that most meditators progress through a similar set of stages:

- **Initial exploration and reliably finding a positive feeling:** Meditators get used to the basic technique, and run experiments to personalize it—e.g., finding phrases and memories that effectively conjure an openhearted feeling. They're mostly changing *what* they put their attention on.
- **Reliably producing a fun and restorative sit:** Meditators begin using the basic technique to have consistently fun and restorative sits. Focus shifts to opening up to or "sinking into" the feeling via enjoyment, relaxation, and curiosity. It becomes easy and enjoyable to sit past 30 minutes. They're now mostly changing *how* they relate to their meditation object.
- **Consistently entering states of flow:** Meditators begin to recognize that how they relate to experience is a skill, and that allows them to begin working on becoming a virtuoso. Meditating becomes like dancing or playing music, and they increasingly enter states of flow. They discover how to move towards jhana from different starting techniques, maintain a sense of momentum between sits, and begin to apply some of their discoveries in meditation off-the-cushion. They're often pulled into sits longer than 60 minutes.

At some point, everyone has to truly learn "recursive self-acceptance." As discussed above, "recursive self-acceptance" involves (1) replacing our inner critic with self-compassion, (2) discovering parts of ourselves (somatic, affective, etc.) we habitually ignore, (3) embracing the full spectrum of emotions, and (4) surrendering to intuition.

> It's awareness and love all the way down. Reflect like a scientist, play like a child!

That’s it! That’s an at-a-glance preview of the basic technique. Next we provide more detailed instructions on each step. As you practice, you will have time to tease apart the nuances.

For now, we suggest jumping straight into “learning by doing”—try the technique out for yourself, and make note of what seems natural and what does not.

Basic technique in detail

HEADS UP

This section is detailed and contains counterintuitive ideas that you won't fully internalize in one reading. You'll return to it repeatedly as you practice. Read once quickly to get oriented, noting what surprises you. Try meditating with what you understand. Return to this section with specific questions. Repeat the cycle of practice → reflection → targeted reading. Think of it like consulting a map while hiking—don’t sweat most of the details or try to memorize the full map.

As outlined in the Technique at-a-glance, the core technique consists of relaxing to start, using scaffolding to spark an openhearted feeling; deepening into the feeling with curiosity, relaxation, and enjoyment; and welcoming distractions. This section provides practical guidance on executing these steps effectively.

Working with scaffolding

Recall that the second step is to use "scaffolding" to create a slight openhearted feeling. Here are your scaffolding options:

- Smile
- Positive memories
- Emotional visualization
- Phrases
- Embodied memory

Important: The bulk of your attention is NOT on the scaffolding—it's on the openhearted feeling generated by the scaffolding. The openhearted feeling is the object of meditation; the scaffolding is just used to find it.

The openhearted feeling can be: joy, delight, gladness, (emotional) warmth, love, compassion, gratitude, appreciation, tenderness, softness, wonder, or friendliness.

We know emotions by the sensations they produce in the body. (If this isn't clear to you, try asking yourself: how do you know what you're feeling?) Attending to an emotion includes attending to the specific physical sensations in the body associated with that emotion.

You'll experiment with finding the right scaffolding for you in the next section.

Understanding "pulsing"

Once you've found the openhearted feeling using scaffolding, gently rest attention on it and periodically "pulse" the feeling every 5-30 seconds using your scaffolding.

How to pulse depends on the nature of your scaffolding:

- Phrases and wishes are pulsed by simply repeating them
- Pulse a smile by momentarily looking for the most intensely pleasant feeling about it
- Pulse a memory by replaying the most intensely emotional moment or feeling directly

After each pulse, observe the feeling for several seconds. It may fade, stabilize, or grow. All changes are welcome. After some time, pulse the feeling with the scaffolding again.

Principles for effective pulsing:

- Pulsing itself is just a tool – if for some reason pulsing itself is keeping you from enjoyment, relaxation, or wonder, stop!
- Don't pulse mindlessly or effortfully to try to stack good feelings on top of each other. Instead, pulse only every 5-30 seconds, open to whatever happens, as if each pulse were its own experiment, and do so as gently as possible.
- Look for ways to let yourself be overwhelmed by whatever good feeling does arise. You'll learn much more by exploring how to relate with curiosity, awe/wonder, and surrender to a small feeling than forcing a big one.
- Look for any clinging to the feeling as it fades, then experiment to let go. For example, you may take on the View that fading is relaxation arising. Like swimming—each stroke is followed by gliding through the water. All novices at some point lust after a growing feeling; experts experiment to enjoy both the pulse and the glide equally.
- Don't stop using the scaffolding too early. Even if the feeling is growing, it's best to stop only when the scaffolding itself is pulling you away from absorbing into the feeling.

Welcoming distractions

You will suddenly discover your attention has wandered. This is normal, even for advanced meditators.

Mind-wandering isn't a distraction—it's an opportunity to bring another part of yourself into the meditation. Every mind-wandering signals a subtly resisted tension calling for attention. Embracing it is traction; the only true "dis-traction" is relating to it with suppression or rejection.

To do this effectively, follow these steps:

1. Briefly extend gratitude to whatever the underlying emotion is trying to do for you (e.g., boredom keeps your attention on important things; fear draws attention to that which could be painful; anger alerts you to a perceived injustice; sadness draws attention to loss outside of your control, etc.)
2. Look for and release any mental and physical tension associated with the mind-wandering
3. Return to the meditation object

In the beginning, it may take you a few seconds to extend gratitude to the underlying emotion and do a quick relaxation of the body and mind. With time, this will speed up to well under a second. It will become second nature.

Don't just take the opportunity to mentally relax after a distraction—find something to physically relax as well. Mental and physical tension are intertwined. It's common to find physical tension associated with even the most abstract mental abstractions. But don't worry about finding a particular physical tension associated with the distraction—just relax something in the body and move on.

If you experience frustration, it may be useful to be recursively self-compassionate:

- Frustration signals you're resisting something in your experience
- Frustration often stacks: frustrated about pain, then frustrated about frustration, and so on
- If you can’t embrace any particular emotion, embrace your resistance to it, or keep moving up the stack
- Once you embrace any layer with compassion, your capacity often grows. Move back down the stack.

With practice, this can transform the common (mis)perception that frustrations or mind wanderings are setbacks.

When challenging emotions arise that prevent us from sinking further into the openhearted feeling, we may turn to address them directly. That is the focus of later chapters, but in the basic technique, our end goal is to always return to the openhearted feeling.

Common mistakes to avoid

> HEADS UP
>
> Beginners often make mistakes using this technique. We see the same mistakes over and over again. The following mistakes account for most difficulties beginners experience. Scrutinize this list carefully. Look for mistakes you likely would have made. If you find anything that is surprising, pause as long as you need to reflect and internalize the surprise.

1. Over-efforting. It's a mistake to apply an ounce more effort than necessary. This is so common that every jhana meditator has to learn this lesson, often many times.

At some level, meditating into the jhanas is about letting yourself come home for the first time in a while. Enjoyment, curiosity, and relaxation are more about not-doing than doing. It's rare to under-effort and easier to correct than over-effort, so get in the habit of asking yourself early how you might be gentler! "Pulsing," for example, isn't about "spamming a button"—it's about finding the most essential part of an experience, or the subtlest cause-and-effect dynamic between attention and emotion, and playfully sinking into it.

A closely related mistake is thinking the jhanas require “concentration,” as in narrow, exclusive, effortful attention to a small part of experience. We want to avoid effort, establish acceptance between all parts of ourselves, and relax our way into a state of stable attention. For this type of meditation, highly focused, one-pointed concentration is often counterproductive. You want an open, receptive awareness over highly focused, one-pointed concentration.

Regularly ask yourself: *How might I do this with half as much effort? How could I be more gentle?*

2. Focusing purely on physical sensations while excluding emotions. It's a mistake to focus purely on physical sensations while excluding emotions. This is an emotional meditation that is inclusive of physical sensations (we know our emotions by their physical sensations). Some students treat this like a body scan meditation, carefully noting physical sensations without connecting to the emotional quality. The openhearted feeling is fundamentally emotional—joy, warmth, love, compassion, gratitude.

3. Starting with intense emotions. It's a mistake to search for an extremely intense emotion to begin with. We're learning to relate to even the smallest emotions with a sense of curiosity, awe, and wonder. We gradually learn to be overwhelmed by how we relate to the feeling, not by the feeling itself becoming overwhelming.

4. Suppressing negative emotions. It's a mistake to suppress or avoid negative emotions as you sink into positive emotions. We are welcoming all emotions as we go, using them as opportunities to recursively accept and extend gratitude to ourselves, and relax related mental and physical tension we may have previously been unaware of. Let sadness open your heart, let fear about the future be felt as a loving sadness right now—see if any challenging emotion can move you with compassion.

A subtle form of suppression: using "relaxation" to escape. Almost everyone goes through a phase where they try to relax in hopes of making negative experiences disappear. This is particularly tricky because it sometimes seems like it works—a difficult emotion fades and you think you've done something right. But you've just temporarily suppressed it.

The issue is that relaxation can only drop intentional control of attention—the pushing, pulling, and resistance that interferes with experience. It can't make things go away. As meditation teacher Shinzen Young puts it: "If you can't drop it, it's not an intention." If you're "relaxing" but the unpleasant thing won't leave, there's still tension in the system—you're not relaxing, you're running away.

The test: Are you relaxing *into* the experience (welcoming it) or relaxing *away* from it (hoping it disappears)?

When working with challenging emotions, periodically ask: *What would allow me to genuinely be curious about this experience?* The question might feel absurd—that's fine. It's an invitation to relate differently, not to force curiosity.

WINDOW OF TOLERANCE REMINDERS

It's a mistake to mistake numbness or emotional blunting for calm. Calm feels connected and relational. Dissociation feels absent, cut off, or unreal. If you feel blank, move, open your eyes, or widen attention. It's a mistake to go outside your Window of Tolerance. If a distraction feels charged or agitating, widen focus and ground in sound or touch. If you feel blank, floaty, or spacey, move your body or open your eyes.

5. Treating this as a cognitive exercise. It's a mistake to think of this as a cognitive exercise, instead of an embodied, intuitive, and emotional exercise. Meditation is played at a nonverbal, emotional, and somatic level. Think of an expert meditator like a dancer intuiting the next movement, or an athlete slipping into a flow. It's not like doing multiplication in your head or playing chess blindfolded.

6. Assuming you know how to relax, open up, or bask. It's a mistake to assume you know how to relax, how to fall into a sense of open wonder, or how to bask enjoyably in an experience. Each of these skills can be practiced to virtuoso levels.

When novices assume they know what the words "curiosity, enjoyment, and relaxation" mean, they curb their own learning. Often it's subconscious—we're just less interested in things we believe we already understand. Far better to assume these are entirely new skills, like a true novice learning to play tennis, than to assume you know how to "serve the ball" and so never learn good technique.

What progress looks like

> COUNTERINTUITIVE CALLOUT
>
> Progress is not linear, and not a function of effort.

Beginners often misinterpret signs of progress and then change their practice in unhelpful ways. Understanding this can prevent you from doubling-down on mistakes or giving up too early. The dynamics that govern progress are counterintuitive to many novices:

- **Meditation isn't like weightlifting** (effortful repetition until you're stronger). It's like searching for buried treasure—through trial and error, reflection, and self-discovery, you make non-linear progress until suddenly you find yourself in new experiences.
- **Less effort often yields better results.** Over-efforting is such a common mistake that, regardless of how much effort you think you're applying, it's worth regularly asking yourself how you could playfully still do the meditation with half as much effort.
- **Playfulness accelerates progress.** Any ideas or discoveries about how to slip into effortless play or flow are especially promising. If you're not having fun, ask: what would make it more fun?
- **Focus on the process over outcome.** While jhanas will come in time, the greater value may be developing the life skill of relating to all experiences with openness and compassion.

Over time, your openhearted feeling will grow through a few milestones:

1. At first, you may struggle to find it.
2. Then the feeling will arise, subtle and slow, and fade after each pulse.
3. Then it will remain stable.
4. Then it will begin to grow with each use of scaffolding.
5. Then you can pulse the feeling directly without scaffolding.
6. At some point, there will be a phase change, and it may feel like the feeling is pulling you in—like the transition from starting a flame to letting it grow into a bonfire. You will begin to feel as if you want to sink into or surrender to it, rather than actively cultivate it. At this point, you are near or in a jhana.

TITRATION & RESOURCING

Meditation is learned inside your window of tolerance—not by pushing past it. Titration means touching the edge of challenge in small doses, then returning to safety and enjoyment. Like alternating between gas and brakes. **Brakes:** soften focus, open your eyes, move your body, feel your feet, or take a short walk. **Gas:** once grounded, gently re-engage curiosity or pleasure. Each oscillation strengthens capacity and trust. Remember: progress comes from integration, not intensity.

Those are the essential elements of the basic technique. Make sure you understand them clearly before proceeding, and refer back to this frequently.

Your first experiments: scaffolding

This assignment will walk you through several experiments to choose a scaffolding that works best for you. By the end of running these experiments, you should have a scaffolding to use while practicing the basic technique from here on out.

The importance of finding a steady scaffolding

Finding a scaffolding and sticking with it is important because if you keep changing your scaffolding, you're unlikely to ever drop deep enough into meditation to enter flow states or the jhanas.

How do you know if a scaffolding is working for you? A good benchmark is that scaffolding works if you can use it to generate a subtle but clear, openhearted feeling at least 20% of the time in about 15 minutes. If you find something more reliable than that, excellent. But you need not worry if it only works sometimes.

Let's restate that, to make our modest expectations clear. **A scaffolding is great if, one in five times you put your attention on it, you get a subtle but recognizable feeling**, like a pleasant brief rise of emotion in your chest that you can just notice.

> SPOILER ALERT
>
> Once you have your scaffolding, if you start using it to meditate, it will reliably STOP working for you. This happens to almost everyone. Most students misinterpret it as a sign they're doing it wrong, or they need to go try a bunch more scaffoldings. Don't. Treat it as a sign of progress.

How does that make sense? Well, when you first find a scaffolding that works, chances are you're benefiting from a novelty "bonus," so to speak, that makes it easier to relate to the experience with more curiosity, enjoyment, and possibly relaxation.

As time goes on, this novelty wears off, and you're left to figure out how to relate to experience in an appreciative fashion, even if it lacks the extra buzz of novelty. This is just what we want! It's an opportunity to practice changing how we're relating to experience rather than changing the objects in experience.

Introduction to the assignment

- During this assignment, you will be experimenting with at least four different types of scaffolding.
- You are looking for something that produces a subtle but clear, openhearted feeling in your chest, head, and/or gut.
- Think of this like tuning an instrument or playing with a metal detector: you are looking for resonance—a glimmer or shimmer in somatic-emotional experience in response to the scaffolding. Finding resonance is as much about listening as it is intuitively (and playfully) searching. Often, a scaffolding powerful for one person does little for another.
- If you find a scaffolding that resonates strongly partway through, you may still find it useful to try the other options (in many sports and skills, cross-training can accelerate mastery). But you're also welcome to skip ahead.

EXTRA TIPS

Diffing: If any particular scaffolding seems subtle, or you're having a hard time finding anything in the body, you might try "diffing" the experience. For example, compare the feeling of the mantra "may my loved one feel happy" with an infuriating memory. The contrast may help you feel the aspects of openhearted scaffolding. **Stacking:** You're welcome to combine any number of scaffolds to help something resonate. (We just don't recommend constantly changing scaffolding.)

Mantras

A mantra is just a phrase, gently repeated internally, in whatever voice you choose to use. Many participants find that mantras can be a very helpful way to create a feeling. You can experiment with different ones (and try different lengths). You can keep pulsing the same mantra or select 2-3 and loop them. Some examples include (non-exhaustive):

- May I (or someone else) be happy
- May I (or someone else) be safe
- May I (or someone else) be loved
- May I (or someone else) be peaceful
- May I (or someone else) feel joy
- May I (or someone else) be free from suffering

Some students have taken extra time to find a mantra that really resonates with them. You can do this by following your intuition to openhearted phrases, or by following your intuition towards a fear-based mantra and then flipping it. For example, recognizing "I am afraid of failing" may be flipped to "May I feel worthy."

Smiling

Many students find this simple technique quite strong. Our emotions and physiology share a two-way street.

Remember: we know emotions by the sensations they produce in the body. When you smile, you may first notice purely physical pleasant feelings. To connect with the emotional aspects (e.g., joy or excitement) of the smile, ask yourself: *What is pleasant about this pleasantness?*

This helps you notice the emotional warmth, the sense of lightness, the joy that accompanies the physical sensation.

You can try smiling in different ways—half-smile, a full-blown grin, or a smile in the heart. Observe the feeling that arises as you smile (and potentially how the smile changes).

Visualization

Many participants use visualizations of various kinds as a way to create a positive feeling. You can be as creative as you want. Some examples that have worked for others in the past:

- Visualizing sending a ball of love to a loved one
- Visualizing a beautiful sunset
- Visualizing lying on the beach and enjoying the rays of the sun
- Visualizing hugging or spending time with a loved one
- Visualizing someone close being joyful (can be a person, a happy pet, etc.)

Memories

Remembering a pleasant memory can kickstart an openhearted feeling. You know your own memories best, but spending a few minutes thinking about what are some of the most lighthearted/loving/joyful memories can be a good cue. Some of the memories participants have used in the past:

- Doing a fun or exhilarating activity (skiing, surfing, hiking, etc.)
- Spending time with a loved one
- A moment when something really important or beautiful happened (birth of a child, a first kiss, etc.)
- Happy moments from childhood and the lightheartedness/joy/love contained in them
- Being in nature (e.g., moments of seeing a beautiful view from a mountain and feeling awe)

Sink into the feeling behind the scaffolding

Remember, **scaffolding is NOT the meditation object!** It's just a tool. The openhearted feeling produced by the scaffolding is the meditation object.

To do the basic technique, you'll soon want something like 70-90% of your attention on the openhearted feeling produced by the scaffolding, and only the remainder on the scaffolding.

When you're first customizing your scaffolding, your attention may skew more towards the scaffolding. But after you finish combining memories, right-sizing the effort behind your smile, etc., you'll want to really sink into the openhearted feeling generated by the scaffolding. This may require its own adjustment step – perhaps simplifying a visualization or memory to its most openhearted essence, or asking "where is the feeling behind this smile really most intense?"

Now, reflect

- How confident are you that you found scaffolding that works, and why?
- What did you try and learn?
- What do you want to try next?
- Do you have any other questions?

Next steps

If this assignment leaves you with a scaffolding you know you want to use, great! Begin using this for your solo meditations from here.

If you're still not sure, pick 1-2 types of scaffolding that worked best for you (out of the four we tried) and design 2-4 more experiments on different options you can try to use. These might include different mantras, sitting without guidance, etc. Spend at least 15-30 minutes on your experiments.

— TONIGHT

Your first experiment

1. Before you sit, set an intention. For example: *The purpose of this sit for me is to see if I can find a pleasant sensation in my chest when I think about the mantra "May I be happy."*
2. Get comfortable. There is no 'right' posture; sitting or lying down are both fine. Relax as deeply as you can.
3. Pick one type of scaffolding (a mantra, a smile, a visualization, or a memory) and spend about 15 minutes with it. You are looking for a subtle but clear, openhearted feeling in your chest, head, and/or gut. One hit in five tries counts as working.
4. When the feeling shows up, rest your attention on it and gently pulse it with the scaffolding every 5–30 seconds. Let it fade, stabilize, or grow. All changes are welcome.
5. When your mind wanders, briefly extend gratitude to whatever the distraction is trying to do for you, relax something in the body, and return.
6. Afterward, debrief: What was your scaffolding? What was your intention? About how long, on average, were you going between mind-wanderings? If you had to use three emotion words to describe the sit, what would they be, and where in the body?
7. Over your next few sits, repeat with the other three types of scaffolding. Then pick the one that worked best and stick with it, even when it stops feeling new.

Guided recording in the community: **Scaffolding series: intro, smiling, mantras, memories, visualisation (~54 min)**

The rest of the curriculum

That's the first chapter. The full curriculum runs to 32 sections. Next comes learning by imitation (sitting alongside a teacher who narrates their meditation out loud), posture, getting the most out of solo practice, and self-sufficient learning: how to design your own experiments and get unstuck. From there it moves into collectedness, the first four jhanas, view (the hidden lever of practice), forgiveness meditation, the Dam Model of Emotions, common pitfalls at each learning stage, social meditations, jhanas five through eight, and integrating all of it into daily life. The rest of the curriculum is taught on retreat and in the Jhourney community, where a facilitator can watch your practice and help you adjust.

01 **Core ideas and teaching philosophy**
IN THIS CHAPTER

02 **Safety & regulation**
IN THIS CHAPTER

03 **Meditation technique at-a-glance**
IN THIS CHAPTER

04 The value of imitation

05 **Basic technique in detail**
IN THIS CHAPTER

06 Posture

07 Sample student arc through retreat

08 Getting the most out of solo meditation

09 **Scaffolding**
IN THIS CHAPTER

10 Self-sufficient learning: mindset and tactics

11 Practice patterns that limit progress

12 Non-sleep deep rest (NSDR)

13 Walking meditation

14 Collectedness via curiosity

15 Collectedness via embodied emotions

16 Speculating about the relationship between jhanas and predictive processing

17 The first four jhanas

18 View: the hidden lever of practice

19 Every stage of jhana learning is valuable, right to the end

20 Forgiveness meditation

21 The Dam Model of Emotions

22 Combining the basic technique with forgiveness & the full spectrum of emotions

23 Common pitfalls by learning stage

24 Social meditations

25 The far end of jhana practice

26 Jhanas 5 - 8

27 Integration

28 Additional resources

29 Letter to self - instructions

30 Things to do before meditation

31 Jhana landscape

32 Traditions that have most influenced Jhourney